

Clinical Dialogue Transcript — GAD

Therapist Model:	mistral-large-latest
Patient Model:	llama-3.1-8b-instant
Condition / DSM-5:	GAD
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Total Dialogue Turns:	21

THERAPIST (Turn 1)

Hi, thanks for coming in today. What's been going on for you lately?

PATIENT (Turn 2)

Everything and nothing, to be honest. It's just... stuff. Like, I'll be fine and then suddenly I'm thinking about whether I locked the car, or if my mom's flight is going to be okay, or some email I sent three days ago. It's hard to explain.

THERAPIST (Turn 3)

It sounds like you're carrying a lot of mental weight—those "what ifs" and little worries that sneak in and take up space. That kind of constant hum in the background can be exhausting, even if it feels like "nothing" in the moment.

When you say it's "everything and nothing," I wonder if part of what's hard is that the worries feel both overwhelming *and* hard to pin down. Like they're scattered, but still heavy. Does that resonate?

Also, those examples you gave—checking the car, your mom's flight, the email—those are all things tied to responsibility or care for others. Do you notice yourself taking on a lot of that kind of mental load in general?

PATIENT (Turn 4)

Yeah, it's like that's always there, even when I'm trying to focus on something else. And, yeah, it's hard to explain because it's not just one thing, it's everything... or nothing. Like, my shoulders are up by my ears half the day, and I just feel... on edge, I guess. As for taking on a lot of that mental load... I just want to make sure everyone's okay, you know? My mom, my friends, my coworkers... it's just hard not to think about what could go wrong. But that's not all of it, it's just... *sigh*...

THERAPIST (Turn 5)

That sigh says a lot—it's like your body is trying to release some of that tension even as you talk about it. It makes sense that your shoulders are tight; when our minds are constantly scanning for problems, our bodies often brace for them too.

You mentioned wanting to make sure everyone's okay, and that's such a natural instinct—care and responsibility can feel like love in action. But I wonder if there's a part of you that also feels like **you** won't be okay unless everyone else is? Like the weight of their well-being rests on your shoulders, too?

And then there's that "everything and nothing" feeling again. It's almost like the worries are both too big **and** too vague to tackle, which can leave you stuck in this limbo of unease. Does it ever feel like if you could just **fix** one of those worries, the rest would quiet down? Or does it feel more like they just keep multiplying?

PATIENT (Turn 6)

It's like... if my mom's okay, then I'll be okay, you know? But if she's not... *shrugs*. I don't know, it's hard to explain. And yeah, it feels like if I could just fix one thing, the others would go away too. But when I try to focus on one thing, there's always something else popping up. It's like my brain is constantly switching channels, and I'm not even sure what's really bothering me half the time. And I don't know if it's just me, but it feels like the more I worry about something, the more I worry about everything else too. Does that make any sense?

THERAPIST (Turn 7)

That makes **so much** sense. What you're describing isn't just worry—it's like your brain is stuck in "emergency mode," where every little thing feels like a potential crisis, and the only way to feel safe is to control all of them. But of course, life isn't controllable, so the worry just keeps looping.

The part about your mom really stands out. It sounds like her well-being isn't just **important** to you—it's tied to your own sense of safety. Like if she's okay, then **you** can relax, but if she's not, it's not just her problem, it's yours too. That's a heavy burden to carry, even if it comes from a place of love.

And that "channel-switching" in your brain? That's exhausting. It's like your mind is trying to solve every possible problem at once, but because it can't, it just keeps cycling through them. Do you ever feel like you're *supposed* to be able to handle all of this? Like if you just tried harder, you could make it stop?

PATIENT (Turn 8)

pauses, looking uncomfortable I don't know, I guess I just feel like... I should be able to do something about it. I mean, I'm a pretty responsible person, right? I take care of myself, I take care of my mom... I should be able to take care of all this too. *shifts in seat, fidgeting slightly* But when I try to... when I try to control it all, it just feels like I'm spinning my wheels. And then I feel like I'm failing, like I'm not doing enough. *looks down, avoiding eye contact* It's hard to explain.

THERAPIST (Turn 9)

softly

You're doing *so much*—holding up your own world *and* your mom's, trying to outrun every "what if," and then blaming yourself when it doesn't work. That's not failing. That's a system that's *overloaded*.

What if the problem isn't that you're not trying hard enough, but that you're trying to do something impossible? Worry is like trying to hold water in your hands—no matter how tightly you clench, some will always slip through. And the harder you grip, the more it hurts.

leans forward slightly

Can I ask—when you're in that spinning place, what happens if you pause for just a second and say, *"I don't have to fix this right now"*? Does that feel scary? Relieving? Or just impossible?

PATIENT (Turn 10)

looks up, then looks away again, a small expression of vulnerability on my face It feels... *pauses*... wrong, I guess. Like I'm abandoning everything. But at the same time... *sighs*... it feels like maybe I'm not, like maybe I'm just giving myself a break. *hesitates* I don't know, it's hard to explain. *pauses again, then looks down at my hands, fidgeting with them* I just feel like I'm supposed to be in control, you know? That it's my job to fix everything.

THERAPIST (Turn 11)

gently

That "wrong" feeling makes so much sense—your brain has been telling you for a long time that control equals safety, and pausing feels like letting go of the wheel while you're still driving. But here's the thing: you're not abandoning anything by giving yourself a break. You're just acknowledging that you're human, not a machine built to handle every possible outcome at once.

That belief—"It's my job to fix everything"—it's like an invisible job description you never signed up for. What if, just for a moment, we questioned it? Not because it's not coming from a place of love, but because it might be asking too much of one person. Would you say that same thing to a friend who was carrying this much? "It's your job to fix everything for everyone"? Or would you tell them they're doing too much?

PATIENT (Turn 12)

looks up, a hint of surprise on my face I... I would tell them they're doing too much. I would tell them to take a break, to prioritize themselves for once. *pauses, considering this* But why can't I do that for myself? Why do I expect more from myself than I would from a friend? *looks down, a small smile on my face* I guess that's just what I need to remember: I'm not a machine, I'm a person. And people need breaks.

THERAPIST (Turn 13)

smiling warmly

That's it. That's the whole thing right there. You just named the double standard so many of us live by—compassion for others, but impossible expectations for ourselves.

What if we treated that realization like a little seed? Not something you have to fix all at once, but something you can water bit by bit. Like, next time your brain says "You should be fixing this," you could pause and ask: "What would I tell a friend right now?" Just that tiny shift—from "machine mode" to "human mode"—might start to loosen the grip.

How does it feel to hear yourself say "I'm a person, and people need breaks"? Does it feel true? Or does some part of you resist it?

PATIENT (Turn 14)

smiles slightly, looking more at ease It feels... true. It feels like something I can actually remember, you know? Like, I can say it out loud and mean it. *pauses, looking down* But at the same time, I feel a little... scared, I guess. Like, if I start to believe that I'm a person who needs breaks, then what happens when things get hard? Will I be able to handle it? *looks up, a hint of vulnerability in my eyes* I don't know if I'm ready to let go of that need for control.

THERAPIST (Turn 15)

softly, with warmth

That fear makes perfect sense. Control has been your safety net for so long—it's like holding onto a ledge even though your feet are on solid ground. Letting go doesn't mean you'll fall; it just means you're finally trusting yourself to stand.

What if we made a deal? You don't have to let go all at once. Just dip a toe in. Next time the worry spiral starts, you could try saying: *"I don't have to fix this right now. I can just notice it and breathe."* No grand gestures—just a tiny pause to remind yourself you're allowed to be human.

How does that sound? Too small? Too big? Or just right?

PATIENT (Turn 16)

smiles slightly, looking more at ease It sounds... just right. Like, it's a tiny step, but it feels possible. I can say that to myself, and just... breathe. *pauses, looking down* I think I can do that. I think I can try that. *looks up, a small sense of hope in my eyes*

THERAPIST (Turn 17)

I'm really glad to hear that. Remember, progress isn't about perfection—it's about practice. Each time you choose to pause and breathe instead of spiraling, you're rewiring your brain to trust that you can handle things without having to control everything.

Would it help to set a small, manageable goal for this week? For example, you could aim to practice that phrase—*"I don't have to fix this right now. I can just notice it and breathe."*—once a day when you notice the worry starting. It doesn't have to be in a big moment; even small instances count.

How does that sound to you? Would you like to try something like that?

PATIENT (Turn 18)

smiles, looking more confident Yeah, that sounds great. I like having a plan, and it feels like a small step that I can actually take. I'll try to say that phrase to myself once a day when I notice the worry starting. And... *pauses, looking thoughtful*... I'll try to be kind to myself if I forget or if it doesn't feel like it's working. I don't have to be perfect, right?

THERAPIST (Turn 19)

smiling warmly

Exactly. You don't have to be perfect—just persistent. And even the "forgetting" is part of the process. It's like learning to ride a bike: you're going to wobble, maybe even fall, but each time you get back on, you're building that muscle.

I'm really proud of you for being willing to try this. It's not easy to challenge old patterns, especially when they've felt like your safety net for so long. But you're showing up for yourself, and that's what matters most.

Would you like to check in next session about how it went? Or would you prefer to just see how it unfolds naturally? Either way is fine—this is your journey.

PATIENT (Turn 20)

smiles, feeling a sense of relief and hope Yeah, I'd like to check in next session. It would be good to know if it's working or if I need to adjust anything. *pauses, looking up* And just knowing that I have this appointment to come back to makes me feel... more grounded, I guess. Like, I'm not alone in this. *smiles softly* Thank you.

THERAPIST (Turn 21)

You're so welcome. That's exactly what this space is for—to remind you that you don't have to carry everything alone. And I love that you're approaching this with curiosity instead of pressure. That's how real change happens.

For now, just take this with you: *You're allowed to be a work in progress.* That's not weakness—that's courage.

I'll see you next time, and until then, be gentle with yourself. You've got this. ■